

GADDAM DHARMENDRA

Former Indian Ambassador to Iran

"High risk of turning into a war of attrition"

The conflict is currently on an escalatory ladder, with a high risk of turning into a regional war of attrition. Iran has successfully warned Gulf Cooperation Council states against hosting US bases while claiming to distance themselves from operations launched from those same facilities. Iran is not Venezuela and calculations of a decapitating strike and regime collapse have shown to be a catastrophic misreading by the US. Equally confounding is the lack of clarity around the US–Israeli war aims and desired endgame. President Trump's announcement that the conflict could last only weeks underestimates Iran's resilience and counter-strike capabilities, which are dragging the US into one of its most consequential conflicts in decades.

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SYED AKIF ZAIDI

Research Scholar, Al-Mustafa International University, Qom, Iran

"Will end in a resounding US defeat"

With the relentless pounding of missiles and drones by Iran, it is becoming clearer with each passing day that this is going to end in a resounding US defeat and its exit as a military hegemon. The US would become just another country—maintaining its embassies and doing business—but no longer able to dictate, dominate or sustain military bases in the region. The second outcome of this war would be the collapse of Israel and the emergence of Palestine. I am not fully confident that this will happen in its entirety in this particular battle, but there will be a regime change in Israel. That point may come within two days; it may take another week or even weeks. It will be followed by a new setup announcing its willingness to admit and accept the creation of Palestine.

"The second outcome would be the collapse of Israel and the emergence of Palestine"



RAJA KARTHIKEYA

Former international civil servant who was posted in Iran

"Four scenarios could bring the war to an end"

There are four scenarios that could bring this war to a closure. The first is military, wherein Iran runs short of missiles or suffers a catastrophic failure in its command-and-control system leading to internal political change. For now, however, the regime is holding, and even consolidating, its position. Two, Gulf countries run out of interceptors against Iranian missiles and decide to fight alongside the US and Israel, in which case the war becomes even more acute. The third is political, wherein facing mounting economic damage, Gulf countries pressure the US to stop the war. The fourth is a wildcard. If the war triggers a major regional economic collapse, larger affected countries, including those with large expatriate populations such as India, push the US toward a ceasefire.

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likely rise in oil prices, the questions everyone is asking are: how destructive will this war be, why did the US and Israel choose to strike now, and just how long it will last.

MISSION DECAPITATION

The decision by Trump and Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu to strike Iran did not have a single trigger. Rather, it appeared to emerge from a convergence of political opportunity, intelligence signals and shifting strategic calculations. The backdrop to the escalation had been set just eight months earlier, in June 2025, when Israel launched its fiercest attack yet on Iran, claiming that Tehran was only months away from developing a nuclear weapon. Both sides exchanged barrages of missiles and drones before Trump authorised Operation Midnight Hammer. Dropping bunker-buster bombs on three of Iran's key nuclear facilities, the US president claimed the strikes had "totally obliterated" Iran's nuclear ambitions. In retaliation, Iran targeted America's Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar with the same number of missiles as US had used to strike its nuclear sites. Claiming that Washington's objectives